Gilly also has the ability to get under just about anything and launch it into the stands. Any bowler stupid enough to bowl short to Gilly inevitably watches the ball disappear into the stands. Ja, his horizontal bat shots, in particular, are unbelievable.

The 102 not out Gilly got against England in Perth during the 2006 Ashes was one of the greatest innings I've ever seen. It took him 59 balls and was the second-fastest Test century behind Sir Viv Richards's 56-ball explosion in 1985. For me, Gilchrist is just as good as any other batter that I've seen.

The Indian Premier League has given me the opportunity to get to know Adam Gilchrist a lot better. Gilly has been with the Deccan Chargers since the inception of the IPL in 2007, and for the last two years he has been our captain. In this time, Gilly has become almost like an older brother to me. He's played 96 Tests and 287 ODIs, so he obviously has a lot of knowledge and experience and, as we both started our international careers in 1996, we've both been down a similar road.

It's great to see how, as a professional cricketer, he keeps everything nice and simple. And he still leads by example with the amount of work he puts in. He has been a revelation to the younger players in the Deccan Chargers.

As our captain, Gilly runs a tight ship – from making sure we are always dressed in the appropriate kit, both on and off the field, to advising and directing the players on the pitch. For example, this past season we were at a function posing for photographs, and I was resting my elbows on my knees. Gilly was like, 'Hersch, straight up, mate!'

He's meticulous and never misses a detail, especially on the field, always seeming to have everything under control out there in the middle. If a bowler's in trouble, Gilly will go and talk to him, but you will never see him really pissed off. If he gets angry, he certainly never shows it. And you can tell that Gilly is always plotting and strategising. Ja, he's really been great for the Chargers – most of his teammates are just in awe of him. I still enjoy watching him stand tall at the crease and dispensing the ball to all corners after all the years of playing both against and, recently, with him.

Matthew Hayden

Charl Langeveldt finds Matthew Hayden very amusing. He just starts laughing when Hayden comes out to bat, because Matt stands directly in front of his wicket and, as a bowler, you can't see any of the three stumps.